Helen Devine
UCLA Social and Affective Neuroscience Statement of Purpose

As a social psychologist, I hope to study decision-making in high-stakes legal contexts and how these judgments differ based on individual differences. My past research experiences have given me extensive preparation and UCLA's Social and Affective Neuroscience PhD program is the best place for me to explore these questions during graduate training.

I first began exploring social psychology during my freshman year at the University of Michigan, where I worked as a study coordinator in Dr. Amie Gordon's Well-Being, Health, and Interpersonal Relationships Lab on a large-scale longitudinal study of how romantic couples navigate stress. I designed a recruitment strategy to bring 218 couples into the lab, ran in-person lab sessions using the Trier Social Stress Test, collected biopsychological data (continuous heart rate, blood pressure, salivary hormones), and coordinated a subsequent two-week daily diary. I also ran follow-ups for a year following initial sessions to track changes in relational quality over time. Learning to manage multiple physiological methods gave me an early foundation in rigorous, multimethod experimental design.

Before my junior year, I was selected as Dr. Gordon's lab manager, a position typically reserved for post-baccalaureates. In collaboration with Dr. Robin Edelstein, I helped launch a study on how romantic couples adapt to first-time parenting by caring for an infant simulator for a weekend. I oversaw the collection of over 2,000 saliva samples and trained our team on an enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay technique. We found that couples with positive expectations about parenting showed decreased testosterone when caring for the infant simulator, suggesting that optimism helps parents adapt more readily to a nurturing role. I am a co-author on the manuscript with an R&R in *Human Nature*. Running a wet lab required rapid mastery of technical protocols, which prepared me to learn new neuroimaging and psychophysiological tools in graduate training.

My interest in high-stakes decision-making under social pressure took shape through my senior honors thesis. I designed two experiments and secured $4,000 in independent funding to test whether the presence of a close friend makes people less likely to comply with an intrusive phone search request ("Can you please unlock your phone and hand it to me?"). Participants overwhelmingly handed over their phones—whether alone or with a friend—despite predicting that they would not comply. Additionally, even bystanders showed heightened physiological arousal (e.g., spiked systolic blood pressure) when watching their friends comply, providing evidence that intrusive requests evoke a stress response that likely affects behavior. I presented this work as a talk at the 2025 *Society for Personality and Social Psychology* legal psychology pre-conference, received the faculty-nominated Pillsbury Award for best thesis, and graduated with Highest Honors. This project showed me how visceral emotional reactions can override deliberative reasoning and sparked my interest in studying these patterns at a deeper mechanistic level.

To expand my training, I earned a lab manager position in Dr. Kurt Gray's Deepest Beliefs Lab at UNC Chapel Hill, which later moved to The Ohio State University. In an ongoing first-authored project, I am investigating whether fear of crime increases victim-blaming. My results suggest

that those who fear victimization are more likely to blame victims, potentially to resolve their own cognitive dissonance. This suggests that efforts to raise awareness about crime may inadvertently increase blame rather than protect victims. I have presented these findings at two national conferences and expanded the project into an NSF Graduate Research Fellowship application. I aim to use this research to reduce victim-blaming by targeting how crime is reported nationally.

My goal as a scientist is to use psychology not only to understand people, but to improve the systems that shape their lives. Alongside my empirical work with Dr. Gray, I co-authored an accepted piece in *Policy Insights from the Behavioral and Brain Sciences* on how psychological perceptions of victimhood diverge from legal expectations. This piece taught me how to communicate science effectively and reinforced my passion for applying decision-making research to reduce inequalities in the justice system.

These experiences have motivated me to pursue graduate studies to better understand how people make high-stakes decisions in real contexts like the justice system. The best place for me to develop this work is in the UCLA Social and Affective Neuroscience PhD program, where I am especially excited about the chance to be advised by Dr. Jaime Castrellon. Dr. Castrellon's work on the neural mechanisms underlying decision-making in social and legal judgments offers the methodologically rigorous training environment I hope to join. I am particularly drawn to his work showing that emotional responses predict downstream decisions, which parallels my findings that fear of crime biases evaluations of victims. I hope to build on this by studying how threat-related neural processes guide moral and legal judgments under uncertainty. Running large-scale experience sampling projects with physiological methods and coordinating studies across multiple institutions has strengthened my ability to quickly acquire technical skills, which I am eager to extend to fMRI and PET methods. I am also excited by the prospect of collaborating broadly in the department, especially with Dr. Naomi Eisenberger, whose work on the neural basis of social connection connects to my interest in the benefits of supportive close relationships.

UCLA's emphasis on rigorous experimental approaches to studying legal decision-making make it uniquely suited for my intellectual goals. I am excited by the prospect of contributing to this collaborative community and pursuing the questions that draw me to study decision-making in the real world.

Helen Devine
UCLA Social and Affective Neuroscience PhD Personal Statement

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When I was nine, my favorite show *Gilmore Girls* introduced me to a motto that I've carried far beyond my childhood home's living room: *In omnia paratus*, "Ready for anything." At the time, it pushed me to pursue every opportunity, but it later became a quiet, consistent philosophy. When I discovered social psychology, I found a field that required the same openness to complexity. This resilience and openness shape what I hope to bring to graduate training.

I conducted research while working throughout college to support myself financially. Balancing jobs with school taught me to manage long hours and made me disciplined and proactive—skills that became crucial once I entered research spaces that were often overwhelming. Navigating roles in science while managing other responsibilities showed me that I could thrive in demanding academic environments.

The moment I knew I wanted to pursue a PhD came during my honors thesis, when one of my research assistants ran into the lab, shocked by the result we had witnessed. I was studying whether people would comply with intrusive search requests, and participants were agreeing to hand over their unlocked phones to a research assistant without hesitation. Our shared excitement over the striking gap between intent and actions made it clear that research is where I feel most at home.

Leading my thesis also solidified my belief that mentorship requires making science accessible. As the only undergraduate manager in many research meetings, I became especially aware of how power shapes who feels comfortable contributing intellectually. I've made it a priority to demystify research: I've mentored eight undergraduate poster presentations, three of which received awards for excellence, and mentored an undergraduate senior weekly on her honors thesis and served on her committee, which received an Honors Distinction. These experiences taught me how people thrive when they know their questions are welcome. I hope to contribute to UCLA's mission to make research spaces accessible, not intimidating.

My commitment to mentorship extends beyond the research lab. As an Academic Peer Advisor at Michigan, I worked one-on-one with students to navigate the psychology major. In my senior year, I was one of two undergraduates on the Academic Affairs committee working with faculty to create courses that better support students. More recently, co-authoring the Substack newsletter *Moral Understanding* with Dr. Gray and co-organizing the inaugural *Science to Impact* conference at Ohio State taught me how to make psychological science accessible beyond academia.

I have also worked as a lab manager at three different universities. Each move meant unpacking and starting over in an environment with new norms. Navigating these transitions on my own taught me how to build community from scratch and support others through unfamiliar transitions—skills that will make me a supportive member of a graduate cohort.

In omnia paratus—ready for anything—captures how I approach scholarship and community. I hope to bring that commitment to UCLA not only as a researcher, but as someone committed to creating spaces where students feel confident asking questions and finding their place.